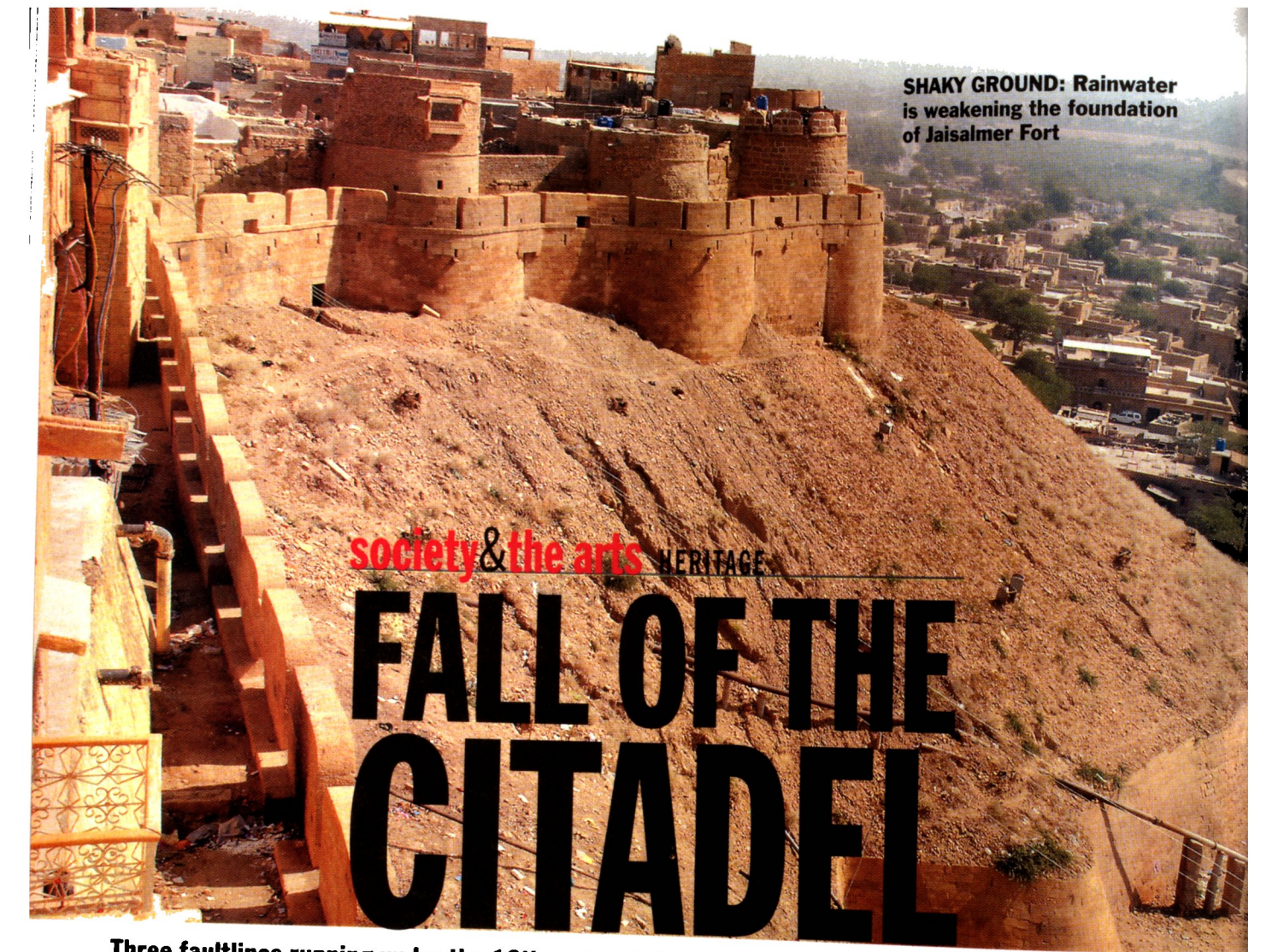




SHAKY GROUND: Rainwater is weakening the foundation of Jaisalmer Fort

society & the arts HERITAGE

FALL OF THE CITADEL

Three faultlines running under the 12th century Jaisalmer Fort, along with a crisis-ridden sewage system and illegal constructions have transformed a threat to heritage into a danger to human life

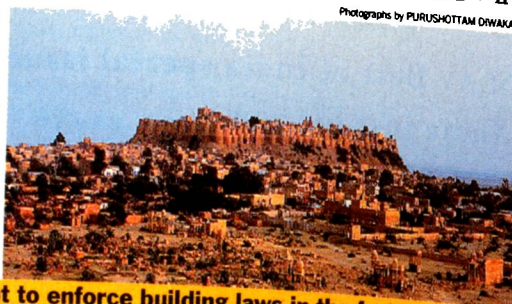
■ By Kaveree Bamzai

In 1993, when the first of Jaisalmer Fort's bastions collapsed, two people got hurt. Alarm bells rang, long enough for some high decibel noise on illegal construction and ambitious plans for a new integrated water management system, finalised in 2001, but yet to be implemented. Now, over two decades later, the golden sand fort, celebrated in Satyajit Ray's *Sonar Kella* (golden fort), which sustains 5,000 people, 350 homes, 37 unlicensed hotels and restaurants, and consumes 12 times the water it did 15 years ago, is under threat from three newly-discovered faultlines running under the fort, suggesting a grave threat not only to the city's heritage but also to its homes. Seventeen of the 99 bastions of the fort, which gets 75,000 foreign and 3 lakh domestic tourists

every year, have already collapsed. *The Lonely Planet* guide has issued a diktat to its readers not to stay within the fort and even the trustee of London-based NGO Jaisalmer-in-Jeopardy (JiJ) Veronica Gledhill Hall now says that for the long-term benefit of the monument, all commercial businesses should be located outside the walls of the fort.

Yet nothing has changed. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has issued 91 demolition notices to home owners who have made unauthorised constructions within the protected

area of the fort, and 55 more are on the anvil. No action is expected. It's the same with the sewage problem. As early as 2001, experts from environmental technology consultancy, SWECO, had pointed to the collection of water in collapsed buildings and told the Jaisalmer ground water department that "the water is likely to prove extremely detrimental to the stability of the fort, since it seeps into the sub-surface slowly and has been seeping over a long period of time". The Geological Survey of India (GSI) data, from ongoing field research, adds to the scare saying: "It is quite possible that the northerly trending lineaments/fractures present south of Jaisalmer and Gadi Sar could have got reactivated during the recent earthquakes and affected mildly the Jaisalmer Fort area. As the fort area exhibits comparatively weaker



Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

CIVIC APATHY Even those meant to enforce building laws in the fort are violating them, including the government